

4

The Tricks of the Trade

I became good friends with Bunty who was managing the treasury operations of a leading non-banking finance company (NBFC) of the time.

One day he came up to me with an unusual request.

‘Lala, I want you to find out what jobber M is up to in the Colgate stock.’

‘What exactly are you looking for?’ I asked him.

‘He is accumulating the stock for somebody, and I am keen to know how much he has bought so far. Even better if he can tell you whom he is buying for,’ Bunty said.

‘M is a seasoned jobber, why would he let me in on the secret?’ I asked.

‘I am not saying he will tell you straightaway. But there may be a way to get it out of him; I am willing to pay up to Rs 10,000 for the information,’ Bunty replied.

‘Seems a tough task, because M is quite discreet about his trades, and I have not heard of any underhand dealings by him,’ I said.

‘Maybe you are right. But figure out a way if you can,’ Bunty said.

That he was willing to pay Rs 10,000 for just information told me how crucial the information was to him.

The following day, I hovered around M to sneak a peek at his *sauda* pad. That did not work. I then tried chatting up M when he was a bit free. But M clammed up as soon I casually mentioned Colgate. He rightly suspected that I was up to something. I did not want to play my final card – an outright bribe of Rs 10,000 for revealing his position in Colgate. If the move backfired I would lose face, not just with him, but with his friends and associates too. I again tried to peep into his *sauda* pad, but by now he